

Phones that Make you Go Mmmm!

Sony Ericsson P800: With a 208x320 pixel, 4,096-colour display, built-in camera and Bluetooth connectivity, this is one power-packed MMS device. It features the Symbian 7 OS and can download Java applications. There is an internal 12 MB and an external 16 MB Memory Stick. It comes with viewers for numerous formats, including Word, Excel and PDF documents, and you can send and receive e-mail, surf the Net and do just about everything a PDA can do.

Nokia 7650: The 7650 features a tiny camera and comes with the Symbian OS. The screen is 176x208 pixels and the phone has Java applications support. This MMS-capable camera-phone features several modes, and images can be captured at a 640x480 resolution.

Sony Ericsson T68i: This is a curvy MMS-enabled phone. It features Bluetooth and has a plug-n-play camera. The screen is a 80x201 pixels, capable of displaying 256 colours. This phone packs in a number of features and boasts of being one of the first to feature MMS. It supports POP3 e-mail and also has 80 KB of internal memory.

Nokia 7210: The 7210 weighs in at a mere 83 grams, features stereo FM radio, and comes with some rather wild colour options and exotic styling. It also features a high-resolution screen, is set as a triband world phone and is Java enabled.

Panasonic GD87/88: This phone boasts of a high-resolution 65,536-colour TFT screen, and an elegant clamshell body design. Did we mention the built-in camera and IrDA support to connect to your PC? The 110,000-pixel CMOS camera also has a built-in timer to take those priceless group pictures!

Of course, your cellular network operator should offer MMS services. Companies around the world are jumping into this. In Japan NTT DoCoMo is a leader, having been in this business for some time now. DoCoMo offers next-generation services such as high-speed 'always on' Internet access at an astounding 384 Kbps—true 3G services. Another emerging market is South Korea, where the DoCoMo's Japanese success story has inspired local carriers to implement 3G-level services. In Europ, service providers such as Orange and Vodafone have just introduced MMS services. In the US, all the big players have introduced or are introducing a whole range of services.

Closer home, BPL Mobile is the first off the block having introduced these services in India. The full range of MMS services available is dependent on the network operator. Compatibility issues may exist initially, but as the standards are finalised, one can expect these to get resolved.



Simon Buckingham
CEO OF MOBILE STREAMS

“The step up from SMS to MMS is as important as the transition was from DOS to Windows for your PC”

The costs

The rate structure for MMS traffic is controlled by the operator, so costs are going to vary from region to region. Within the same region, expect the costs to be more or less identical once all the operators implement MMS. Internationally, customers get charged either on a per message basis or by the amount of data transferred in the MMS message. There are also some tariff plans that charge a flat rate for Internet access (this would include MMS), over a fixed period. As a basic guide to the cost of an MMS message, the Mobile Stream's MobileMMS forum at www.mobilemms.com suggests a rate equal to three times the rate for one SMS message. Ultimately though, the rates will be set by the operators themselves.

I don't wanna be left out!

Maybe you don't have a mobile phone or, even more frustrating, your device does not support MMS. So you feel left out? No

problem. Realising that the penetration of MMS-enabled phones is going to be slow, the standard setters have a simple strategy: use e-mail to send and receive MMS messages.

Don't expect to do this overnight, though. Implementation and functionality depend upon the network operators. Industry insiders such as the Mobile Streams believe that this is going to be a primary driver for the MMS services to take off, so once rivalries kick in, everybody should be offering it. Those with SMS enabled phones should receive a URL pointing to where the message has been stored.

The future

Now that users will get a taste of what multimedia messaging offers, the need for greater support for audio and video in a handheld device is only going to increase. Perhaps the single most influential driver that would facilitate true multimedia and advanced forms of interactive messaging will be a cellular service network that allows for greater bandwidth. We've already heard of 3G networks like NTT DoCoMo, which offers bandwidths of up to 384 Kbps on a mobile device. Tomorrow's 4G networks are going to boast of wireless bandwidth like most people can only dream of. In Octo-

ber, DoCoMo announced the impossible: under experimental conditions, with a working prototype of a 4G mobile system, an incredible 100 Mbps downlink and 20 Mbps uplink conditions. This, DoCoMo claims, is the fastest data transmission achieved to date over mobile links. DoCoMo itself is looking at the key technology being developed by 2005 and possible commercial deployment of the 4G architecture by 2010. The possibilities that this kind of bandwidth, coupled with the slew of more advanced mobile devices, is going to bring is only limited by one's imagination. However, MMS will become popular only when prices come down and services and devices become easily available. Analysts predict that it would be a couple of years before MMS reaches the same level of acceptance and reach as SMS. But for now, MMS holds promise and is a definite step towards pictures, sound and video on your mobile device. ■

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